

Genre Analysis of Linguistics and Literature Research Article Abstracts in English and Arabic

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Abstract: The abstract, being the primary section readers encounter in a research article, has been recognized as a distinct genre in the field of genre analysis. This study seeks to contribute to that effort by analyzing the rhetorical structure of moves within the disciplines of linguistics and literature, through a comparison of abstracts authored by Arab scholars in both English and Arabic. The study initially aimed to compare the rhetorical moves across four disciplines: English linguistics, English literature, Arabic linguistics and Arabic literature. It then examined the similarities and differences between abstracts in the two languages. To this end, a sample of eighty abstracts in linguistics and literature gathered from six university-published journals in six different Arab countries was analyzed using Hyland's (2000) model. The findings showed that the method move was the most recurrent, while the conclusion move was the least. It has been found also that the English linguistics contained more patterns, whereas the Arabic literature showed the least patterns; and that the English abstracts were more in compliance with the prescribed model than the Arabic ones. Furthermore, the study uncovered unclassified patterns in Arabic abstracts that could be attributed to the nature of the discipline and its academic environment.

Keywords: Genre analysis; moves analysis; research article abstracts; rhetorical structure.

تحليل النوع التركيبي لملاحظات الأبحاث العلمية في مجالي اللغويات والأدب باللغتين العربية والانجليزية

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مستخلص البحث: يعد ملخص البحث العلمي الواجهة الأولى التي يقع عليها نظر القارئ في البحث، ولهذا فقد أولى اهتماما خاصا باعتباره نوعا تركيبيا متميزا مما يجعله موضوعا جديرا بالدراسة والبحث في مجال تحليل النوع التركيبي للأبحاث العلمية. تهدف الدراسة الحالية الى المساهمة في هذا الجهد من خلال تحديد الهيكل البلاغي للخطوات التركيبية لمخصص البحث في مجالي اللغويات والأدب عن طريق مقارنة الملاحظات المكتوبة باللغتين العربية والانجليزية لباحثين من العالم العربي. تسعى الدراسة الى مقارنة الخطوات التركيبية في أربع تخصصات: اللغويات الإنجليزية، الأدب الإنجليزي، اللغويات العربية، والأدب العربي؛ كما تهدف الى كشف أوجه الشبه والاختلاف بين ملخصات الابحاث في اللغتين. وتتكون العينة من ثمانين ملخصا تم جمعها من ست دوريات علمية صادرة في ست دول عربية مختلفة وتم تحليلها باستخدام قالب هايلاند (2000). وقد أظهرت النتائج أن خطوة المنهجية كانت الأكثر تكرارا في جميع العينات، بينما خطوة الخاتمة كانت الأقل؛ وأن ملخصات اللغويات الإنجليزية احتوت على خطوات تركيبية أكثر، بينما ملخصات الأدب العربي كانت أقل. وكشفت الدراسة أن الملخصات باللغة الإنجليزية كانت أكثر امتثالا بالقالب المعتمد مقارنة بالملخصات باللغة العربية. علاوة على ذلك بينت الدراسة أن هناك أنماطا لم يتم تصنيفها بحسب القالب المعتمد في مجموعة الملخصات العربية ويعزى ذلك الى نوع التخصص وطبيعة بيئته الأكاديمية.

الكلمات مفتاحية: تحليل النوع التركيبي ، تحليل الخطوات ، ملخصات البحوث العلمية.



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1. Introduction

Research articles have been the subject of investigation over the last two decades. It has covered a variety of genres including, the introduction (e.g. Alharbi, 2016; Fakhri, 2009; Öztürk, 2007; Samraj, 2002), the methodology (e.g. Tawalbeh, 2019; Tawalbeh, 2021), the discussion and the conclusion (e.g. Arabi, 2019; Amnuai & Wannaruk, 2013; Ruiying & Allison, 2003), and the abstract (e.g. Alharbi & Swales, 2011; Alhuqbani, 2015; Amnuai, 2019; Kaya & Yagiz, 2020; Magday et al., 2022; Putri & Kurniawan, 2021).

Research on research article abstracts has recently garnered increased attention. Undoubtedly, the abstract plays a crucial role in a research article, as it is the first section readers encounter and encapsulates the essence of the entire article (Hartley, 2003). Just like the research title, the research abstract can inform readers about the main aspects in the research paper. According to Bhatia (1993), the purpose of an abstract is ‘a description or factual summary of the much longer report and is meant to give the reader an exact and concise knowledge of the full article’ (Bhatia, 1993, p. 78). In addition, abstracts can also invite readers to the quality of the paper and make them decide to continue reading it. Indeed, the abstract is “the point at which [readers] decide whether to continue and give the accompanying article further attention or to ignore it” (Hyland, 2002, p. 63). Hyland (2004) also asserts these dual purposes of the abstract as to provide a concise summary of the research and to attract the reader’s interest.

Due to the abstract’s critical role, it is essential for writers, therefore, to capture their readers’ attention and persuade them to continue reading their articles from the first encounter (Hyland, 2009). Consequently, academic institutions and publication outlets have given abstracts special attention by setting guidelines and rules for writing them. Researchers, in turn, have shown increasing interest in this genre, exploring a variety of topics including rhetorical move structure (e.g. Putri & Kurniawan, 2021), linguistic features (e.g. El-dakhs, 2020), and pedagogical applications (ElSerty, 2024). Recently, researchers have shown significant interest in investigating the rhetorical structural moves of abstracts by comparing different disciplines and languages. This study, therefore, intends to add to

this venture by looking at research article abstracts in the fields of linguistics and literature written in English and Arabic. The fields of linguistics and literature have been selected in this study as they often yield theoretical and non-empirical research. Swales & Feak (2004) categorize research in literature and linguistics to be theoretically oriented because logical argumentations in these fields are formed in a “general-specific structure” (Swales & Feak, 2004, pp. 278). Even though a significant portion of research has been conducted in research article abstracts comparing both English and Arabic abstracts, very few seem to have investigated abstracts in theoretical and non-empirical areas such as linguistics and literature, particularly those written by Arab researchers. This study, therefore, attempts to fill this gap. Specifically, this study aims at identifying both the rhetorical move structure in abstracts written in English and Arabic in the fields of linguistics and literature, as well as the similarities and differences between abstracts in English and Arabic in the fields of linguistics and literature. In line with the above objectives, the study intends to address the following research questions:

What are the rhetorical move structures in abstracts in the fields of linguistics and literature written in English and Arabic?

What are the similarities and differences between abstracts in English and Arabic in the fields of linguistics and literature?

2. Literature review

2.1 Genre Analysis

Genre and genre analysis have been under study for a long time. Three major approaches have been prominent: the systematic functional approach led by Halliday and Hassan; the rhetorical approach pioneered by Bazerman, Myers and Millerand; and the ESP approach, which was developed by Swales and has gained widespread acceptance and been highly influential. According to Swales (1990, p. 58), a genre is a class of communicative events that share particular sets of communicative purposes recognized by distinct communities. Likewise, (Swales & Feak), define genre as “a type of text or discourse designed to achieve a set of communicative purposes” (2009, pp. 1). The communicative aspect of genre adopted by this approach has spurred further research in various fields, including move analysis.

2.2 Move Analysis

A move is a “discoursal or rhetorical unit that performs a coherent communicative function in a written or spoken discourse” (Swales, 2004, p. 228). The communicative functions of the moves have been identified in different forms such as sentences and paragraphs. For this purpose, moves have been used in studying academic genres across disciplines (e.g. Swales, 1990) and across cultures (e.g. Alhuqbani, 2013).

Move analysis was first pioneered in Swales (1981) with the introduction a four-move model for the research papers. Later, in Swales (1990) a revised version of the model was presented. In response to further critiques, Swales (2004) provided an update for the CARS model with three moves and eleven steps. On the other hand, the first model for analyzing research article abstracts appeared in Bhatia (1993). This model comprised four moves (Move 1 - Introducing purpose Move 2- Describing methodology Move 3- Summarizing the results Move 4- Presenting conclusion). Criticizing Bhatia’s (1993) model for lacking an introduction move, Santo (1996) presented a new model which contained five moves. In response to Bhatia’s (1993), Hyland (2000) introduced a model which has attracted widespread attention among researchers. The model uses five moves as shown below:

Move	Function
Introduction	Establishes context of the paper and motivates the research or discussion.
Purpose	Indicates purpose, thesis or hypothesis, outlines the intention behind the paper.
Method	Provides information on design, procedures, assumptions, approach, data, etc.
Product	States main findings or results, the argument, or what was accomplished.
Conclusion	Interprets or extends results beyond scope of paper, draws inferences, points to applications or wider implications.

Table 1: Hyland’s (2000) classification of rhetorical moves in article abstracts

This model has been widely favored over other models due to its extensive use in previous research and proven effectiveness in analysis. For the present study, this model has been selected as it distinctly separates the introduction and purpose moves, offering a broader perspective on categorizing

abstracts. Additionally, its ease of implementation and extensive application in the literature enhances its potential for facilitating more reliable cross-study comparisons.

2.3 Review of relevant studies

A) Studies across languages

Previous studies have investigated research article abstracts in different cultures and disciplines. Below is a brief review of some. One relevant study was Kaya & Yagiz (2020), which attempted to compare abstracts in the field of English language teaching written by Turkish and non-Turkish scholars working in Anglophone countries. Applying Hyland’s (2000) model and using descriptive statistics, 390 research article abstracts were investigated. The findings showed no statistically significant differences regarding moves. The results also revealed that three moves (purpose, method, product) were frequently employed in Turkish writers’ abstracts, whereas four moves (purpose, method, product, conclusion) were more common in foreign writers’ abstracts.

Likewise, Pratiwi et al. (2021) attempted to compare master and doctorate theses written in both English and Indonesian using Hyland’s (2000) model. The study aimed to analyse differences in discourse patterns, frequency of moves and their linguistic features realization differences between abstracts written in English and Indonesian. The findings showed that the moves of introduction and conclusion were common in English abstracts, while the methods move was common in Indonesian. As for linguistic features realization, it was found that the use of tense was different, whereas voice and verb usage showed considerable similarity.

Similarly, Duan and Wei (2021) investigated legal abstracts in both Chinese and English. Using a combined four-move model, they analyzed a corpus of 60 abstracts in terms of move frequencies and features and similarities and differences in the two languages. The results demonstrated that the introduction move was obligatory, while the methods move was optional. It was found also that the English abstracts appeared with more moves than the Chinese ones.

Another interesting study was Magday et al. (2022), which used Hyland’s (2000) model to compare two sets of corpora of research article

abstracts in the field of education. The study used 116 abstracts, which were divided equally between Filipino conference writers and international conference writers. The findings showed three common moves between the two groups: purpose, method and product. The findings showed also that the local conference abstracts were lengthier and contained a greater number of words.

Along the same line, Nguyen et al. (2024) examined research article abstracts in law using Hyland's (2000) model. Employing a qualitative analytical approach, the study used 50 abstracts from open access journals indexed in Web of Science and Scopus. The findings revealed that the purpose move was the most used one and the method move was the least.

B) Studies on research article abstracts in Arabic

Comparing research article abstracts in Arabic and English has been under investigation by several researchers in varied disciplines. One of the early studies was Alharbi & Swales (2011), which investigated research article abstracts written in English and Arabic by the same researchers in science. The study looked at a corpus of 28 research article abstracts for the purpose of comparing the rhetorical and linguistic features in the two languages. The findings revealed that the move structure used in the Arabic abstracts was basically simple, as they focused on background and results. Another important finding was that the Arabic abstract showed more rhetorically interactive style than the English ones. This was attributed to the authors' focus on the message rather than the format.

Similarly, Alhuqbani (2013, 2015) attempted to look at abstracts written in Arabic language. In his (2013) study, he examined abstracts in four disciplines: law, linguistics, medicine and police. Using Bhatia's (1993) four-move structure and Hyland's (2000) five-move structure, 40 abstracts were analyzed. The findings showed that the abstracts in the four disciplines were varied in terms of adherence to the models. The findings show also that even though the abstracts in medicine looked closer to the models, the abstracts in the other three areas had no conventional move structures. In Alhuqbani (2015), he compared abstracts in the fields of police and security. The findings revealed that the main moves were purpose, method, and

results and that the conclusion was mostly unused.

In the same vein, Alotaibi (2013) attempted to study English and Arabic abstracts in two disciplines: educational psychology, and sociology, using both Swales' (1990) and Hyland's (2000) models. The findings showed differences in abstracts between languages and disciplines.

Along the same lines, El-dakhs (2020) compared between research article abstracts in education written in both English and Arabic. Applying Hyland's (2000) model, a corpus of 400 abstracts was investigated in terms of rhetorical structure and interactional features. The findings showed that English abstracts used normal conventions of writing abstracts, while Arabic abstracts simply focused on method, purpose and results. The findings also revealed that English abstracts contained lengthier introduction and conclusion moves, whereas Arabic abstracts included lengthier method and findings moves.

Another interesting study was Fallatah (2016), who looked at research article abstracts written by Saudi writers in three different contexts: English local articles, English international articles and articles written in Arabic. Using Swales & Feak's (2009) model, three sets of a total of 93 abstracts were analyzed. The findings showed that the Saudi local abstracts were different from the international ones in many aspects including, move presence fluctuation, move cyclicity, verbosity and excessive use of citation.

Likewise, Bouziane & Metkal (2020) attempted to compare 112 research article abstracts in the field of applied linguistics in three languages: Arabic, French and English, using Hyland's (2000) model. The findings revealed that abstracts written in English and those written in Arabic by middle eastern writers followed the existing conventions of writing abstracts, while abstracts written in French and those written in Arabic by north African authors did not follow any particular pattern.

Another relevant study was Al-Zubi & Fareh (2023), who looked at differences and similarities in English and Arabic abstracts in medical contexts. Using Hyland's (2000) model, a sample of 120 abstracts taken from three major medical journals in the Arab world was analyzed. The findings demonstrated that the two sets of data were similar in move structure, with the method and the product

moves being obligatory, while the introduction move was optional.

A more recent study is ElSerty (2024), which compared between articles in English for academic purposes (EAP) and Arabic for Academic Purposes (AAP), employing Hyland's (2000) model. Data comprised of ten research articles taken from internationally scholarly journals. The study revealed variations in the structure of the moves, but not in the move frequency between EAP and AAP abstracts. The study also disclosed differences in the lexical, syntactic and rhetorical features of writing abstracts in these disciplines.

Taking into account the aforementioned review of studies above, the present study is intended to contribute to the existing literature by providing new insights into the move analysis of research article abstracts in the fields of in linguistics and literature in both English and Arabic.

3. Methodology

3.1 Data collection

The present study used four sets of data: English linguistics, English literature, Arabic linguistics and Arabic literature. The data were composed of 80 research article abstracts (20 in each set) that were published between 2021 and 2022. These articles come from two disciplines: linguistics and literature. These disciplines were chosen due to the significant amount of theoretical and non-empirical research conducted in these areas. The research article abstracts that were randomly selected were sourced from six journals that belong to six universities in six different Arab countries. These journals are Journal of Arts and Human Sciences, King AbdulAziz University, Saudi Arabia; Journal of College of Arts, Alexandria University, Egypt; Journal of Arts, University of Baghdad, Iraq; Journal of Arts and Human Sciences, Damascus University, Syria; Journal of Human Sciences research, AlNajah University, Palestine; Journal of Arts and Human Sciences, AlSharijah University, Unite Arab Emirates. These journals were purposely selected as they belong to official institutions in different Arab countries. This is to ensure the articles follow rules set by accredited institutions such as universities rather than other online open-access journals.

3.2 Data analysis

This study employed Hyland's (2000) model as a tool to analyze the data of abstracts. As seen in Table 1 above, the model contains these five moves: Introduction (M1), Purpose (M2), Method (M3), Product (M4), and Conclusion (M5). These abstracts were then systematically identified and numbered for later analysis, with each abstract assigned a unique identifier reflecting its language and sequence, such as ALIT1 for the Arabic literature research article abstract no. 1, and EL2 for abstract no.2 in the English linguistics set. Based on the model, the presence and frequency of the five moves have been coded. For this purpose, both qualitative content analysis and quantitative analysis (frequency and mean) have been employed to identify rhetorical moves employed in the abstracts. In order to identify obligatory and optional moves, this study adopted Swales' (1990) categorization in which moves that occur no less than 50% were considered obligatory, whereas moves with less occurrence than 50% were considered optional. As for the analysis of the second objective regarding similarities and differences between the two languages, the data obtained from the two sets in each discipline were combined and were then examined as two sets. For reliability, analysis of samples from the abstracts were discussed with experts from the English and Arabic departments.

4. Results and discussion

The presentation of the results obtained from this study is divided into two sections. Move analysis within disciplines, and similarities and differences between moves in the two languages.

4.1 Move Analysis

The first objective of this study is to consider the analysis of abstract moves within the disciplines of linguistics and literature. Table 2 below illustrates the findings gained from the data.

Moves	English		Arabic		Mean
	Linguistics	Literature	Linguistics	Literature	
Introduction (M1)	100 %	85%	60%	65%	15.5
Purpose (M2)	90%	85%	80%	70%	16.25
Methods (M3)	75%	60%	75%	35%	12.25
Product (M4)	75%	35%	40%	40%	9.5
Conclusion (M5)	35%	15%	20%	15%	4.25

Table 2: Frequency of moves in the four sets of abstracts

The findings above reveal that the purpose move [M2] is the most recurrent and compulsory move in the four sets, as it receives the highest mean score (16.25). Opposite to that is the conclusion move [M5], which is the least recurrent move in the data, for it receives mean score of (4.25). These findings are in accordance with Bouziane & Metkal (2020), who identified the purpose move as the most obligatory in their three sets of data: French, English and Arabic.

In order to determine the obligatory moves in each discipline, this study has adopted Swales' (1990) classification. Referring to Table 1 above and based on this classification, we can observe that the most obligatory moves in English linguistics are four: M1, M2, M3, M4, whereas the most obligatory moves in English literature are three: M1, M2, M3. The most Obligatory moves in Arabic linguistics are three: M1, M2, M3, while the most obligatory moves in Arabic literature are two: M1, M2. It can be noticed here that, apart from English linguistics (four moves), the other sets show three or less obligatory or optional moves i.e. one of them adheres to the five-move model. This can be attributed to the nature of the fields of linguistics and literature being commonly non-empirical. As (Swales & Feak) note, theoretically oriented fields do not follow the standard abstract's structure (Swales & Feak, 2004, pp. 278). When comparing these findings to the previous studies, we can observe that they align with the findings of (Kaya & Yagiz, 2020), who reported that not all abstracts used the five-move model. This is also in agreement with Alhuqbani (2013, 2015), who found that the moves of purpose, methods and results were obligatory in linguistics.

As for the optional moves, it has been found that the least optional moves are product move [M4] in English literature, Arabic linguistics, Arabic literature; methods move [M3] in Arabic literature; and the conclusion move [M5] in all the sets. Furthermore, Arabic literature appears to be the least of all sets to adhere to the number of moves, as three moves are optional and only two are obligatory. This might be attributed to the nature of the field of literature being more theoretically oriented. This also aligns with Alhuqbani (2015), who reported that the conclusion move was optional in the fields of policy and security.

4.2 Similarities and differences between moves in languages

To respond to the second objective of the study regarding similarities and differences between the two languages regardless of the discipline, the analysis of the data is exhibited in Figure 2 below. As we can see, the English set appears to be higher in employing all the five moves. This shows one difference between researchers in the two languages, as the English set shows more compliance with the model, with four moves go above 20 abstracts (out of 40). Even with the least used move i.e. the conclusion move (M5), English abstracts show higher percentage than the Arabic ones. This finding is in accordance with some of the previous studies such as Bouziane & Metkal (2020) and El-dakhs (2020), who found that abstracts written in English were conformed more with the models than the abstracts written in Arabic.

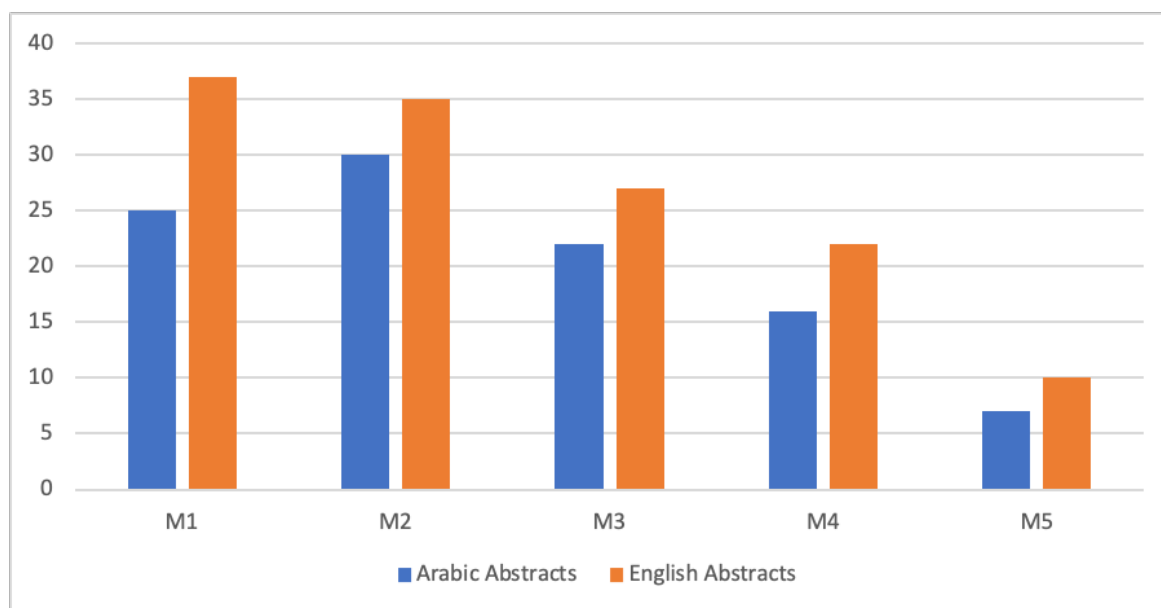


Figure 2: Moves in English and Arabic

Furthermore, data in Figure 2 uncover that the obligatory moves in English abstracts are four: M1, M2, M3, M4, whereas there is only one optional move which is M5. The obligatory moves in Arabic abstracts are M1, M2, M3, whereas M4 and M5 are optional moves. This finding corresponds with a previous finding in this study that abstracts written in English show more compliance with the model than the Arabic written abstracts, even though the authors come from the same geographical environment. These findings are also in accordance with previous research such as Fallatah (2016), who found that English abstracts applied more moves than the Arabic ones in the Saudi context. Likewise, Bouziane & Metkal (2020) reported similar findings with researchers in Arabic from the middle east, but not with those Arab researchers from north Africa. This was attributed to the north African researchers' greater familiarity with the English tradition of writing abstracts as compared to their counterparts in the middle east. These findings seem to reveal that the abstracts in Arabic need to be given further attention.

When comparing the data of Arabic abstracts, it has been noticed that there were sentences that could not be categorized using Hyland's (2000) model and new patterns were identified. These patterns appeared in twelve abstracts out of 40, which makes %30 (5 in linguistics and 7 in literature). Further examination of these patterns led to their categorization into two

distinct moves which were subsequently labeled "structure move" and "subheadings move".

Structure move: The data from the Arabic sets uncovered a pattern in which these researchers dedicate a sentence or more to present the main structure of their research paper. This was found in six abstracts (two in linguistics and four in literature). Here are two examples from the data:

Excerpt 1

This research has been divided into an introduction, two sections and a conclusion. This is then followed by a list of references. (ALIT 2)

انقسم البحث على: مقدمة ومبحثين وخاتمة، وألحقت بها ثبوتا بالمراجع. (ALIT 2)

This research work has come in an introduction, four sections and a conclusion. (AL 16)

وقد جاء البحث في مقدمة وأربعة مباحث وخاتمة. (AL 16)

The study consisted of four sections, that were preceded by an introduction and followed by a conclusion. (ALIT 19)

وجاءت الدراسة في أربعة مباحث يسبقها تمهيد وتُعقبها خاتمة (ALIT 19)

As can be seen, these sentences are intended to present the structure of the paper by referring to its main sections such as the introduction, and the conclusion. In excerpt 2, the authors give more details about the study based on the sequence of the sections of their studies. This was found in four abstracts (one in linguistics and three in literature). Here are two examples:

Excerpt 2

This interweave and alternation between the two stories was the first section in this study. This has been preceded by a preamble on the concept of time in the story, and an introduction that showed the research questions and the previous studies. In the second section I discussed the major time discrepancies...in the third section I talked aboutand I finally concluded with the results and the recommendations. (ALIT 4)

I started with a preamble that briefly introduces Al-Akhfash and Al-Baqooli... Then, I explained the concept of "altaaqubat". After that I started reviewing those "taqubat" in ten sub-sections: the first one was the structural analysis of "fi" meaning "mouth"...In the second sub-section I discussed the subject positioning ... In the tenth sub-section I concluded by reviewing the meaning of "taajub"... (AL 14)

وقد كان هذا التداخل والتناوب بين القصتين محور المبحث الأول في هذه الدراسة، بعد أن سبقه تمهيد عن مفهوم الزمن في الرواية، ومقدمه عرضت أسئلة البحث المهمة والدراسات السابقة ، وفي المبحث الثاني تناولت أبرز المفارقات الزمنية...وفي المبحث الثالث تحدثت عن ... ثم ختمت بأبرز النتائج والتوصيات. (ALIT 4)

وبدأت البحث بتمهيد يشمل التعريف بالأخفش والباقولي بإيجاز... ثم بينت مفهوم التعقبات، وبعد ذلك بدأت في دراسة تلك التعقبات من خلال عشرة مباحث، عرضت في المبحث الأول: لأعراب «في» بمعنى «فم»... وتحدثت في المبحث الثاني عن رفع الفاعل... ثم ختمت الحديث في المبحث العاشر عن معنى «ما التعجبية»... (AL 14)

As can be seen, the researchers in these two examples present the sequences of the sections of their research one after the other.

Subheadings move: Another pattern that has been identified in the Arabic abstract set which could be seen different from the model is a pattern that provides subheadings and numbering. For instance, abstract AL9 starts with introductory sentences and then three subheadings (written in bold): study aims,

study methodology, and study findings. Under study aims, all the three study aims are written. Under the subheading "methodology", a brief description of the methodology used in the study is presented in three lines. The last subheading "from the study results" is followed by two points that summarize the main results of the study. The first point is written in three and a half lines, whereas the second one was two lines. Here's an excerpt for this abstract.

Excerpt 3

Research aims: 1) follow-up of Al-serafi values ...
2) Highlight the beauty secrets ...
Methods: The theoretical aspect employed a descriptive method...
Main results: 1) Alserafi values have contributed ...
2) Alserafi stud on ... (AL9)

أهداف البحث: (1) تتبع القيم للسيرافي...
(2) بيان الأسرار الجمالية..
منهج البحث: راعت الدراسة في الجانب النظري المنهج الوصفي..
من نتائج البحث: (1) أسهمت القيم الحجاجية في ..
(2) وقف السيرافي ... (AL9)

This finding seems to align with Alhuqbani (2013), who identified such patterns in abstracts in medicine. According to Alhuqbani (2013), these kinds of patterns show keenness of researchers for highlighting the major moves in their abstract. It seems that those researchers are alert to ensure that their readers can easily encounter what they might look for once they start reading the abstract.

Having uncategorized moves in abstracts in languages other than English has been previously identified in the previous research. For instance, Magday et al. (2022) found a new move in the abstracts written by Pilipino researchers in the field of education. Previous research in Arabic has also shown similar findings. For instance, Alharbi & Swales (2011) identified an uncategorized move

in Arabic abstracts in science in which researchers presented the structure of the paper, as has been identified in the present study. According to Alharbi & Swales, the Arabic researchers used that move to provide “a comprehensive roadmap to the paper in much the same way that speakers often outline their talks at the outset”, (2011, pp.79). This was attributed to the “culturally conceptualized rationale of abstracting Alharbi & Swales (2011, pp. 80).

The findings above show diversity in writing abstracts that seem to be even different from what is conventional in the western academic context. This perhaps uncovers particularities between the two academic cultures that need to be investigated in further research.

5. Conclusion

The purpose of this study was to investigate the move structure of research article abstracts in linguistics and literature written in both English and Arabic in journals published by Arab universities. Additionally, the study aimed to compare similarities and differences between the two languages with regard to moves. Data were composed of 80 research article abstracts in four disciplines: English linguistics, English literature, Arabic linguistics, and Arabic literature. The findings demonstrated that the methods move [M2] was the most recurrent among the four disciplines, whereas the conclusion move [M5] was the least. The findings also showed that English linguistics contained an obligatory pattern that contained four moves [M1, M2, M3, M4], while both English literature and Arabic linguistics showed the same pattern that contained three moves: [M1, M2, M3]. The least obligatory pattern was in Arabic literature where only [M1, M2] were the most obligatory patterns identified. The findings also revealed variation between languages with relation to move structure as English written abstracts were more in compliance with the model than the Arabic written abstracts even though the authors were from the same environment.

With respect to similarities and differences between the two languages, the findings revealed that the English abstracts were more compliant with the model than the Arabic ones. The findings also demonstrated variation in the obligatory moves between languages, as the obligatory moves in

English were four, whereas the obligatory moves in Arabic were three. A significant result revealed in this study is regarding the patterns identified in the Arabic abstracts that were not matching with the moves in Hyland's (2000) model. These seem to confirm a significant difference between the two languages. Even though the authors of the two sets of abstracts utilized in this study come from the same Arabic environment, the distinct move structures observed in the Arabic data may suggest that the abstract conventions in these disciplines need further examination.

Drawing upon the aforesaid study findings, a few recommendations can be proposed. A deeper analysis of the move structure of abstracts in Arabic, particularly in theoretical fields such as linguistics and literature, needs to be conducted to explore any unidentified conventions or moves. As ascertained by Hyland, the difference in patterns we may come across might represent the researchers' “choice of how best to convince others of their work” (Hyland 2004, p. 75). Researchers in these disciplines may employ distinct rhetorical patterns to persuade readers of their work. This, indeed, appears to be an attractive area to be studied further. Furthermore, an investigation into the publication guidelines established by Arab journals in the fields of linguistics and literature, and researchers' responses to these procedures could perhaps be beneficial. Undeniably, editors play an influential role in shaping the final product of not only abstracts but also all other genres of the research paper.

A limitation of this study is its restriction to two disciplines: linguistics and literature. Hence, further research in non-empirical research abstracts in other fields such as management and law, particularly in Arabic, may provide a richer perspective. The current study is also limited to reliance on a sample of eighty abstracts. Further research with larger samples might bring new insights and more robust conclusions.

6. References

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